

B0B04B22 - Anglický jazyk B2-2

WEEK 11

Listening Practice

Reading Skills for Academic Study – Summarizing* & Note-Taking**

Summarizing* effectively is crucial in academic writing for demonstrating comprehension, building arguments, and avoiding plagiarism. It requires understanding the source material, identifying key ideas, and expressing them concisely in your own words. This skill is essential for successful academic work at the university level.

Note-taking** is crucial in academic English for enhanced understanding, memory retention, and critical thinking by actively engaging with the material and organizing complex ideas into a personal record. It aids in identifying key concepts, structuring written work, avoiding plagiarism by tracking sources, and preparing for exams, ultimately leading to better academic performance.

LISTENING

You will hear a short lecture entitled 'Struggling with Abstraction.' For each of the questions below (1 – 5), choose the answer (a, b, or c) which fits best according to what you hear. You will hear the recording twice. **CIRCLE** your answer (a, b, or c).

(1) According to the speaker, many people consider "abstract" to be a negative term because it...

- a) ...is overly focused on objects.
- b) ...implies a disconnection from reality.
- c) ...is only used by the effete.

(2) Based on how the speaker uses it, what is the best definition for "hamstrung?"

- a) Significantly limited in your ability to do things.
- b) Punished unfairly to protect someone else.
- c) Unfocused or directionless.

(3) The speaker says that the idea of caloric...

- a) ...was originally invented in the 1800s.
- b) ...is used to accurately describe reality.
- c) ...is a useful abstraction.

(4) Caloric is described as mystical because it was associated with a God-centric view of the world.

- a) True
- b) False
- c) Not enough information given

(5) Overall, the speaker argues that...

- a) ...focusing too much on details is unproductive.
- b) ...abstraction makes people uncomfortable.
- c) ...we must pay attention to all of the data our senses receive.

VOCABULARY PRACTICE:

Form used in text:

Use the correct form to complete the sentences below:

- | | |
|-----------------|--|
| (1) REDUCE | The dean introduced a rare _____ in tuition costs. |
| (2) PERFECTLY | It is unfair to expect _____ from any human endeavour. |
| (3) IMPRACTICAL | It takes hundreds of hours of _____ to become a master. |
| (4) CALCULATE | Before smartphones, _____ were important school supplies. |
| (5) ESSENCE | Turkey is an _____ feature of the American Thanksgiving table. |
| (6) SENSE | The police encouraged people to act calmly and _____. |
| (7) SOLVED | What's the _____ to the problem of mass immigration? |
| (8) ACCIDENT | We _____ went to the restaurant on the wrong night, but they still able to serve us. |
| (9) DISCOMFORT | The mother tried to _____ the crying child with little success. |
| (10) LITERALLY | The _____ meaning of the word "gymnasium" is "place to train naked." |

Struggling with Abstraction

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Read the following text and fill in the blank spaces [1 - 15] with the correct preposition.

There are NO BLANK SPACES.

After reading, decide if you would like to change any of your answers for the listening practice on page 1.

Today, we think about thinking abstractly. The University of Houston's College of Engineering presents this series about the machines that make our civilization run, and the people whose ingenuity created them.

Abstraction is such an off-putting word! An object-oriented society turns it (1) _____ a bad word. It's good to be down-to-earth; it's effete to be abstract. Yet we live by abstractions all the time. I can say a scarf is green without showing anyone the scarf. You know the color of leaves, or the backs of dollar bills, or moldy cheese. You've abstracted vegetation and money to the point where you understand green apart (2) _____ any object.

We engineers would be hamstrung without abstraction. We absolutely have to reduce real machinery to frictionless pulleys, point masses, and perfectly insulated bodies. If we didn't, we'd drown (3) _____ intractable detail. We'd never get (4) _____ to making anything.

Here's an example: Heat flows through a slab of steel heated by boiling water on one side and cooled by ice cubes on the other: The boiling water agitates atoms on one side -- makes them jiggle faster. Those atoms agitate the atoms next (5) _____ them, and so on. On the other side, the ice slows the moving atoms and absorbs their energy. As you move (6) _____ hot to cold, each atom passes energy on to the next one. Finally all that motion passes into the ice. And the ice gradually melts away.

It's completely impractical to calculate heat flow (7) _____ describing such a complicated process, so we do a strange thing. We go back to an 18th-century abstraction. Before we had an atomic theory, we imagined an invisible substance called caloric flowing (8) _____ hot objects to cold ones. There is no such material, but no matter. You can describe heat flow just fine by imagining caloric. Our mathematical theory of heat flow still comes to rest (9) _____ an 18th-century abstraction.

Hardly anyone remembers that invisible and mystical essence, caloric. Yet we still use the idea. We abstract reality (10) _____ a way that's unrealistic. When would-be realists catch (11) _____ to that, they shrink back, even though we'd flounder without it.

So realists with good sense do set (12) _____ abstract parallel universes. When an invented world truly runs parallel to the messy world around us, then a problem solved in the imagination is also a problem solved in the real world. The public, uncomfortable with the ways of science, fights that kind of down-home good sense.

A person might chance thousand-to-one odds of having a car accident (13) _____ vacation and yet be terrified (14) _____ million-to-one odds of getting cancer from Alar. But then statistics is one more abstraction of human experience that we use to make sense (15) _____ reality -- one more locus of discomfort if we need things cast in concrete. Shaping worthwhile abstractions means extracting the essence of reality from the clutter of sense data. It is, quite literally, a matter of seeing more -- by knowing how to see less.

I'm John Lienhard, at the University of Houston, where we're interested in the way inventive minds work.

SUMMARIZING

One of the most important aspects of reading for academic study is reading so you can make use of the ideas of other people. This is important as you need to show that you have understood the materials you have read and that you can use their ideas and findings in your own way. In fact, this is an essential skill for every student. Spack (1988, p. 42) has pointed out that the most important skill a student can engage in is “the complex activity to write from other texts”, which is “a major part of their academic experience.” It is very important when you do this to make sure you use your own words, unless you are quoting. You must make it clear when the words or ideas that you are using are your own and when they are taken from another writer. You must not use another person’s words or ideas as if they were your own: this is PLAGIARISM, and plagiarism is regarded as a very serious offence.

A summary is a shortened version of a text. It contains the main points in the text and is written in your own words. It is a mixture of reducing a long text to a short text and selecting relevant information. A good summary shows that you have understood the text.

EXAMPLE:

SOURCE	SUMMARY
The amphibia, which is the animal class to which our frogs and toads belong, were the first animals to crawl from the sea and inhabit the earth.	The first animals to leave the sea and live on dry land were the amphibia.

The phrase “*which is the animal class to which our frogs and toads belong*” is an example, not a main point, and can be deleted. The rest of the text is rewritten in your own words.

The following step may be useful in learning to summarize:

- 1) Read and understand the text carefully.
- 2) Think about the purpose of the text.
 - Ask what the author’s purpose is in writing the text?
 - What is your purpose in writing your summary?
 - Are you summarizing to support your points?
 - Or are you summarizing so you can criticize the work before you introduce your main points?
- 3) Select the relevant information. This depends on your purpose.
- 4) Find the main ideas – what is important.
 - They may be found in topic sentences.
 - Distinguish between main and subsidiary information.
 - Delete most details and examples, unimportant information, anecdotes, examples, illustrations, data etc.
 - Find alternative words/synonyms for these words/phrases – do not change specialized vocabulary and common words.
- 5) Change the structure of the text.
 - Identify the meaning relationships between the words/ideas – e.g. cause/effect, generalization, contrast. Look at Paragraphs Signalling for more information. Express these relationships in a different way.
 - Change the grammar of the text: rearrange words and sentences, change nouns to verbs, adjectives to adverbs, etc., break up long sentences, combine short sentences.
 - Simplify the text. Reduce complex sentences to simple sentences, simple sentences to phrases, phrases to single words.
- 6) Rewrite the main ideas in complete sentences. Combine your notes into a piece of continuous writing. Use conjunctions and adverbs such as ‘therefore’, ‘however’, ‘although’, ‘since’, to show the connections between the ideas.
- 7) Check your work.
 - Make sure your purpose is clear.
 - Make sure the meaning is the same.
 - Make sure the style is your own.

PRACTICE:**[Page 4]**

Match the summaries below (a - p) to the following source texts (1 - 7).

There are 9 summaries that are incorrect (e.g., NOT actual summaries, support, etc.) – do not use them.

SOURCES:

- (1) People whose professional activity lies in the field of politics are not, on the whole, conspicuous for their respect for factual accuracy.
- (2) Failure to assimilate an adequate quantity of solid food over an extended period of time is absolutely certain to lead, in due course, to a fatal conclusion.
- (3) The climatic conditions prevailing in the British Isles show a pattern of alternating and unpredictable periods of dry and wet weather, accompanied by a similarly irregular cycle of temperature changes.
- (4) It is undeniable that the large majority of non-native learners of English experience a number of problems in attempting to master the phonetic patterns of the language.
- (5) Tea, whether of the China or Indian variety, is well known to be high on the list of those beverages which are most frequently drunk by the inhabitants of the British Isles.
- (6) It is not uncommon to encounter sentences which, though they contain a great number of words and are constructed in a highly complex way, nonetheless turn out on inspection to convey very little meaning of any kind.
- (7) One of the most noticeable phenomena in any big city, such as London or Paris, is the steadily increasing number of petrol-driven vehicles, some in private ownership, others belonging to the public transport system, which congest the roads and render rapid movement more difficult year by year.

SUMMARIES:

- a) Most people do not like politicians.
- b) The British drink a large amount of tea.
- c) Public transport is better than private vehicles.
- d) Many learners find English pronunciation difficult.
- e) English sentences are difficult.
- f) Big cities have growing traffic problems.
- g) Some long and complicated sentences mean very little.
- h) London and Paris have a lot of petrol-driven vehicles.
- i) British weather is changeable.
- j) The words pronounce and pronunciation do not sound the same.
- k) It rains a lot in Britain.
- l) Politicians often lie.
- m) Solid food is better than liquid food.
- n) The longer the sentence, the less it makes sense.
- o) Britain gets all of its tea from China and India.
- p) If you do not eat, you die.

Taking notes is an important part of student life. There are two main reasons why note-taking is important:

1) When you are reading or listening, taking notes helps you concentrate. In order to take notes – to write something sensible – you must understand the text. As listening and reading are interactive tasks, taking notes help you make sense of the text. Taking notes does not mean writing down every word you hear; you need to actively decide what is important and how is related to what you have already written.

2) Notes help you to maintain a permanent record of what you have read or listened to. This is useful when revising in the future for examinations or other reasons.

Good notes should be accurate, clear and concise. They should show the organization of the text, and this should show the relationship between the ideas.

EXAMPLE:

STEP 1: Read the passage carefully twice from beginning to end.

STEP 2: Remember your purpose: to describe the formation of a volcanic island.

STEP 3: Select the relevant information

STEP 4: Mark all the points which should come into your answer.
Do this very carefully, and be sure not to miss anything.

SOURCE:

The **birth** of a volcanic **island** is an event marked by prolonged and violent travail: the forces of the **earth** striving to create, and all the forces of the **sea** opposing. At the **place** where the formation of such an island begins, the **sea floor** is probably **nowhere more than about fifty miles thick**. In it are deep **cracks and fissures**, the results of unequal cooling and shrinkage in past ages. Along such lines of **weakness** the molten lava from the earth's interior presses up and finally **bursts** forth **into the sea**. But a submarine volcano is **different from a terrestrial eruption**, where the lava, molten rocks, and gases are hurled into the air from an open crater. Here on the bottom of the ocean the volcano has resisting it all the weight of the ocean water above it. Despite the **immense pressure** of up to two or three miles of sea water, the new **volcanic cone** builds **upwards towards** the surface, in flow after flow of lava. Once within reach of the waves, its soft ash is violently attacked by the motion of the water which continually **washes away its upper surface**, so that for a long period the potential island may **remain submerged**. But eventually, in new eruptions, the cone is pushed up into the air, where the **lava hardens** and **forms a rampart** against the attacks of the waves.

STEP 5: Make notes:

- island formation: earth versus sea
- where? sea bed, not more 50 miles thick, cracked and uneven
- weak lava bursts through
- c.f. land volcano: no sea pressure
- how? lava cone pushes upwards
- surface – washed away by waves submerged
- lava hardens island

STEP 6: Using this list of points, write your rough draft, referring to the original only when you want to make sure of some point.

1st DRAFT:

A volcanic island comes into being after a long and violent struggle has taken place between the forces of the earth and the sea. The island begins to form when hot lava breaks through weak points on the sea-bed where the earth's crust is not more than fifty miles thick and is marked by deep cracks. The volcanic island, unlike a land volcano, has to push up through the immense pressure of the sea. The cone made up of lava finally reaches the surface, but it does not appear because waves wash away its upper surface. When the lava hardens it stands up to the waves and the island is formed.

STEP 7: After correcting your draft, write an accurate copy of your text.

SUMMARY:

A volcanic island is born only after a long and violent struggle between the forces of the earth and the sea. It begins to form when hot lava breaks through a cracked and uneven part of the sea-bed where the earth's crust is weak. Unlike the land volcano, it has to build upwards despite the immense water-pressure until it finally reaches the surface. Even then it is too soft to withstand the waves and remains underwater until the cone is pushed into the air from below and the lava hardens.

STEP 8: Check your work.

Take care to make your text accurate.

Your sentences should be well connected to each other so that your text reads as a continuous paragraph.